

MODULE 19 / 40

Baltimore Oriole

*Icterus galbula***QUICK STATS**

Length	6.7 – 7.5 in (17 – 19 cm)
Wingspan	9.1 – 11.8 in (23 – 30 cm)
Weight	1.1 – 1.4 oz (30 – 40 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 6 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Baltimore Oriole is one of the most spectacular and eagerly awaited migrants in eastern North America — the male's blazing flame-orange and jet-black plumage is rivaled by few birds on the continent. Named after the colors of Lord Baltimore's coat of arms, it is the state bird of Maryland and a beloved symbol of spring. Its arrival at feeders in late April and May — often announced by its rich, fluty, whistled song from the canopy of an elm or cottonwood — is one of the most anticipated events of the backyard birding year. It is uniquely attracted to halved oranges and grape jelly offered at specialized feeders.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Baltimore Oriole breeds across the eastern United States and southern Canada, from the Great Plains east to the Atlantic coast and from southern Canada south to northern Georgia and Oklahoma. It is a long-distance migrant, wintering from southern Mexico south through Central America to northern South America. It inhabits open deciduous and mixed woodland, forest edges, riparian corridors, orchards, parks, and large suburban gardens with tall trees — particularly elms, cottonwoods, and maples. It nests high in the canopy of large trees.

DIET & FEEDING

- Halved oranges skewered on a feeder spike — irresistible to orioles
- Grape jelly in a small shallow dish — a top feeder attraction
- Nectar feeders (oriole-style, with larger ports)
- Ripe dark berries: mulberries, serviceberries, cherries
- Insects and caterpillars — the core of the breeding-season diet
- Flower nectar probed directly from blossoms

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Baltimore Orioles are solitary and territorial during the breeding season, with males defending territories through song and aerial chases. They are canopy specialists, spending most of their time high in the crowns of tall trees where they are often heard before they are seen. Despite their shyness in the treetops, males readily come down to feeder stations offering oranges and jelly. They are migratory, departing for the tropics as early as late July — among the earliest fall migrants of any North American songbird. Fall birds show more subdued plumage than spring males.

NESTING & BREEDING

The Baltimore Oriole builds one of the most remarkable nests of any North American bird — a deep, sock-shaped pouch woven from plant fibers, grasses, and string, suspended from the tip of a high, drooping branch. The female does all nest construction, weaving the structure over 1–2 weeks. Clutches of 4–5 pale grayish eggs with dark scrawls are incubated by the female for 12–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 12–14 days. One brood per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Baltimore Oriole's song is a series of rich, fluty whistles — clear, melodious phrases that carry well from the treetops. Each male has a distinctive song with regional dialects. The call is a dry, rattling chatter and a clear whistled "hew-li" contact note. Females also sing — their song is shorter but similarly rich in tone. Song is heard primarily from arrival in late April through mid-summer.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The Baltimore Oriole population is estimated at 12 million individuals but has declined by approximately 24% since 1970. Loss of large elms to Dutch Elm Disease removed a favored nesting tree across much of its range. Additional threats include habitat loss on wintering grounds, pesticide use reducing insect availability, and window collisions. Planting native berry-producing trees and offering feeder food in spring are meaningful ways to support this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Put out halved oranges and grape jelly by May 1 — before arrival
- Use a dedicated oriole feeder with orange-colored ports and fruit spikes
- Place feeders in the open near tall trees — orioles need clear flight paths
- Replace jelly and fruit every 1–2 days in warm weather to prevent spoilage
- Plant native serviceberries and mulberries — natural magnets for orioles

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head & back (male)	Deep black
Breast & belly (male)	Brilliant flame orange
Wings (male)	Black with white wing bar
Female — overall	Olive-yellow to dull orange
Female — wings	Dark brown with two wing bars
Bill	Long, pointed, blue-gray

COLOR ME!

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